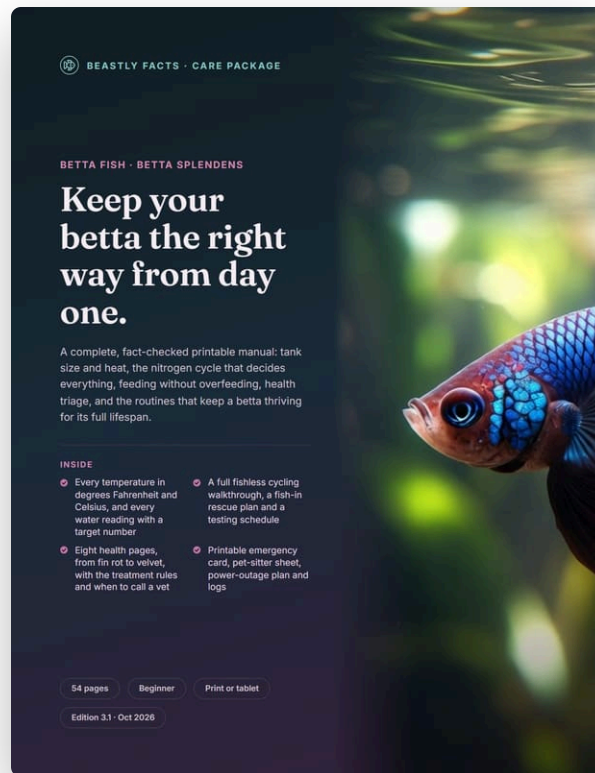


FREE SAMPLE

Betta Fish Care Package

The first 5 pages of the 54-page printable manual, free to keep.



In this sample: What's inside, How to Use This Package, Quick Profile & Cost Overview, The Species, Size & Lifespan. The contents page shows every one of the 54 pages, so you can see exactly what the full package covers before you buy it.

Not in this sample: the 49 pages that follow, which are the full care guide, the health section, the quick reference cards, and the owner tools, checklists and logs.

The full package is \$8.99 at beastlyfacts.com/care-packages/betta-fish/. One purchase, and every corrected edition is a free re-download from your library. The free betta fish care guide it was built from is at beastlyfacts.com/guides/betta-fish/, and stays free.

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature is given in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside it. Tank volumes are in gallons (gal) with liters (L) beside them, sizes in inches (in) with centimeters (cm), and heater power in watts (W). Water readings are in ppm, parts per million: the unit a test kit prints, where 1 ppm is one part of a substance in a million parts of water. A percent (%) is how much of the tank's water you change, or how much of a food is protein. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 6 to 14 in order before buying anything, and before buying the fish. The single most important rule in this book is that the tank is cycled before a betta goes in it, and cycling takes weeks, not an afternoon. Use the Budget & Shopping List on page 38 to buy once, then start the cycle on page 9 while the fish is still in the shop.

If your betta is already set up

Go straight to the Setup Checklist and Targets on page 36 and audit what you have. If the tank has no heater, no gentle filter or no liquid test kit, fix that this week. If your betta already looks unwell, start at Red Flags on page 28, but test the water first: the answer is in the test tube far more often than it is in the medicine cabinet.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Page 36: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 45: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 37: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 46: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 41: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 47: Equipment, Water Change & Vet Log |
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WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Bettas are commonly sold as bowl fish, in cups and unheated bowls, and that picture is out of date. This package reflects current tank-size, heating, cycling and enrichment standards, cross-checked against the veterinary and scientific sources listed on page 52.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A veterinarian who treats fish. Most betta problems are solved by correcting the water, but the serious or unclear ones need an aquatic vet, and those are fewer than vets for dogs, cats or reptiles. Find one now and write the number on the emergency card.

SECTION 01 · PROFILE

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Betta splendens</i> , also called the Siamese fighting fish
Adult size	2.5 to 3 in (6 to 7.5 cm). Males carry the showier fins, which is finnage, not extra size
Captive lifespan	2 to 4 years typical, up to 5 with excellent care
Native range	Thailand, Cambodia and Vietnam: shallow rice paddies, floodplains and slow streams
Diet type	Obligate carnivore (it needs meat), a surface ambush feeder. A betta-specific pellet is the staple, never flakes (page 15)
Tank minimum	5 gal (19 L), heated, filtered, cycled and lidded. Bigger is easier to keep stable (page 6)
Temperature	76 to 82°F (24.5 to 28°C), with 78 to 80°F (25.5 to 26.5°C) the sweet spot
The one hard rule	Ammonia and nitrite read 0 ppm, always. Any other reading is an emergency (page 11)
Housing	One male per tank. Clear access to the surface is a physiological need, not a nicety
Handling difficulty	Beginner, but observation only. Never bare hands (page 20)
Conservation status	Vulnerable on the IUCN (International Union for Conservation of Nature) Red List, the global list of threatened species, for wild populations

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$150 to \$360 for the equipment and first food, plus \$5 to \$30 for the fish itself (up to about \$55 for a rare variety), so \$155 to \$390 all in. Every line is on page 38.

Ongoing

\$10 to \$25 a month for food, conditioner, filter media, test reagent refills and the heater's electricity, which is \$120 to \$300 a year.

WHERE THE MONEY ACTUALLY GOES

Not the fish, and not the food. A betta eats a few pellets a day, so the real recurring cost is the electricity to run a heater around the clock. The heater and a proper filter, which the bowl-and-fish bundle leaves out, decide whether the fish thrives.

Fun facts worth knowing

- A betta breathes air. The labyrinth organ lets it take oxygen straight from the surface, an adaptation to the shallow, sometimes low-oxygen water it comes from. It also means a betta blocked from the surface has a real problem.
- Males build bubble nests out of saliva-coated air bubbles at the surface, and captive males do it with no female present.
- A betta in its shop cup can sit in fouled water for days and still be alive: Kajimura and colleagues (2023) found them unusually tolerant of ammonia, possibly from generations of shipping in small bags. Tolerance is not health.

The species, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

One species

The pet betta is *Betta splendens*, the Siamese fighting fish. It comes from the shallow rice paddies, floodplains and slow-moving streams of Southeast Asia, in Thailand, Cambodia and Vietnam. Low-oxygen water pushed it to evolve the labyrinth organ that lets it breathe air directly from the surface. Males are famous for flowing fins and vivid colors, and for intense aggression toward other males: the name "fighting fish" comes from organized fighting matches held in Thailand centuries ago. A betta is a solitary fish, and a male lives alone.

Color and fins

Wild *Betta splendens* are a comparatively dull olive-brown. The vivid reds, blues and iridescent colors in shops are almost entirely the result of centuries of selective breeding. Males are typically priced higher than females, mostly for their showier fins and color, not for any difference in care.

Size and lifespan

Adult size	2.5 to 3 in (6 to 7.5 cm) of body. The long, flowing fins are what make a male look larger.
Lifespan	2 to 4 years is typical in an aquarium, and up to 5 is reachable with excellent care.
Wild lifespan	Not separately documented in the wild.

A betta past its second birthday is genuinely old. Split and thinning fins on a fish that eats well, swims normally and holds its color are consistent with age: the same damage that closed over in two weeks at one year old may never fully close at three. Clean water still helps, but it stops being a cure (page 30).

How the species reached the hobby

The fish entered Western science as a diplomatic gift. In 1840 the king of Siam handed breeding stock to Theodore Edward Cantor, a Danish physician, and nine years later Cantor published the first scientific account of them under the name *Macropodus pugnax*. That name was already taken, and in 1909 the ichthyologist Charles Tate Regan corrected it to *Betta splendens*, the name still in use. The hobby spread on its own track: Pierre Carbonnier was importing and breeding them in France by 1874, Paul Matte brought the first specimens into Germany from Moscow in 1896, and importers in California appear to have received them around 1910.

A FISH THAT NEEDS MORE THAN IT IS SOLD WITH

Bettas are often sold in small cups or bottles with no filter and no heater, and they tolerate that far better than most fish would, which is how the myth of the low-maintenance bowl fish survived. The care in this package is what the same animal needs to live its full lifespan: a heated, filtered, cycled tank (page 6).